

flea

NEWS 97 April 2026



FLEA NEWS is a twice-yearly newsletter about fleas (Siphonaptera). Before including in publications any of the citations given here, please review for accuracy and correct formatting. Many of our sources are abstracting journals and current literature sources, and editors have not necessarily checked citations.

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Announcements

68th annual Livestock Insect Workers Conference
to be held June 28th through July 1st, 2026 in Santa Fe, New Mexico.

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Siphonaptera taxonomy Lewis World Species Flea List available on data platforms gbif (Global Biodiversity Information Facility), CoL (Catalogue of Life), and planned for TaxonWorks.

Hastriter, M. W., & Bossard, R. L. (2026). Robert E. Lewis World Species Flea (Siphonaptera) List (version 3.0). In O. Bánki, Y. Roskov, M. Döring, G. Ower, D. R. Hernández Robles, C. A. Plata Corredor, T. Stjernegaard Jeppesen, A. Örn, T. Pape, D. Hobern, S. Garnett, H. Little, R. E. DeWalt, J. Miller, T. Orrell, R. Aalbu, J. Abbott, C. Abreu, A. Acero P, et al., Catalogue of Life (2026-02-13 XR). Catalogue of Life Foundation, Amsterdam, Netherlands. <https://doi.org/10.48580/d48fy>

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Fleas on TaxonWorks
by Josh Pletcher

I am working on building a comprehensive database of flea taxonomy, nomenclature, biogeography, host associations, biology and literature using the TaxonWorks platform. Check out some of the other projects using this system such as the:

Orthoptera Species File (<https://orthoptera.speciesfile.org/>)
World Ichneumonidae Database (<https://worldichneumonidae.com/>)
Universal Chalcidoidea Database (<https://ucd.chalcid.org/#/>)
Curculionidae of the World (<https://catalog.curculionoidea.org/#/>)

to get an idea of what I'm envisioning.

Please get in touch with me (josh.pletcher.2021@owu.edu) if you would be interested in

contributing to this project. Particularly if you have access to any obscure publications on fleas, I would be very excited to receive pdf scans of them so they can be added to the database. Josh Pletcher



Fleas of the World

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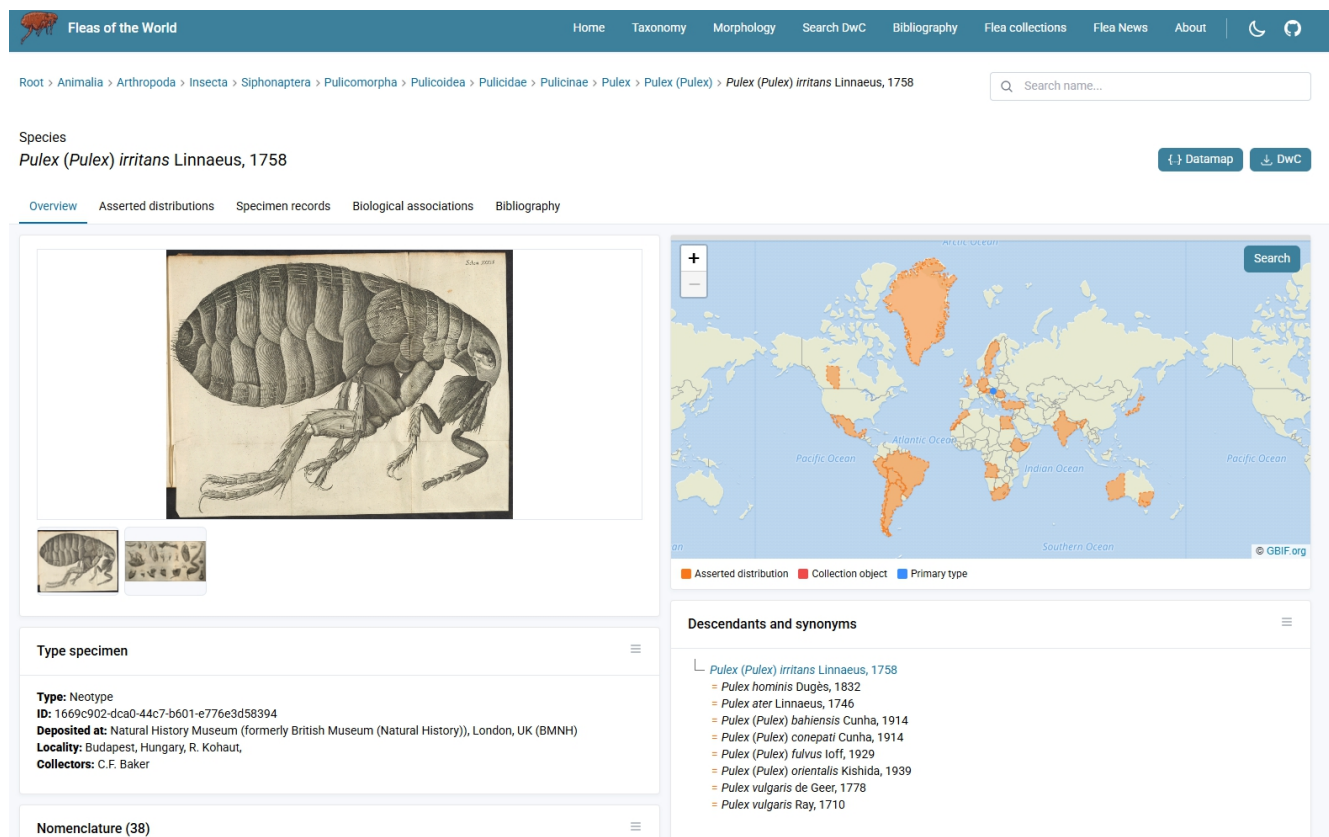
Fleas of the World

A comprehensive database of global flea diversity

Search by taxon name...

NK317589.F1 *Mesopsylla hebes*

Fleas are ectoparasitic holometabolous insects in the Order Siphonaptera. Several species of fleas are important in human and veterinary medicine, most notably as vectors of plague. Fleas are found on all seven continents, including Antarctica, and are primarily associated with small mammals. Other species of fleas are associated with birds, humans, carnivores and ungulates. Unlike other ectoparasitic insects such as



Fleas of the World

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Root > Animalia > Arthropoda > Insecta > Siphonaptera > Pulicomorpha > Pulicoidea > Pulicidae > Pulicinae > Pulex > Pulex (Pulex) > ***Pulex (Pulex) irritans* Linnaeus, 1758**

Search name...

Species

***Pulex (Pulex) irritans* Linnaeus, 1758**

{ } Datamap ⬇ DwC

Overview Asserted distributions Specimen records Biological associations Bibliography

Type specimen

Type: Neotype
ID: 1669c902-dca0-44c7-b601-e776e3d58394
Deposited at: Natural History Museum (formerly British Museum (Natural History)), London, UK (BMNH)
Locality: Budapest, Hungary, R. Kohaut,
Collectors: C.F. Baker

Nomenclature (38)

Map

Search

Asserted distribution Collection object Primary type

Descendants and synonyms

- Pulex (Pulex) irritans* Linnaeus, 1758**
 - Pulex hominis* Dugès, 1832
 - Pulex ater* Linnaeus, 1746
 - Pulex (Pulex) bahiensis* Cunha, 1914
 - Pulex (Pulex) conepati* Cunha, 1914
 - Pulex (Pulex) fulvus* Ioff, 1929
 - Pulex (Pulex) orientalis* Kishida, 1939
 - Pulex vulgaris* de Geer, 1778
 - Pulex vulgaris* Ray, 1710

Siphonaptera Literature (2025)

(with new citations and some repeats from the previous FN)

New Flea Species

(2025)

Gong Zhengda, Wen Xiangbing, & Li Chunfu. (2025). A STUDY ON THE TAXONOMY AND FAUNA OF SIPHONAPTERA IN THE TIBET AUTONOMOUS REGION, CHINA VI: DESCRIPTION OF A NEW SPECIES OF GENUS FRONTOPSYLLA FROM SOUTHEASTERN TIBET, CHINA (SIPHONAPTERA: LEPTOPSYLLIDAE). Journal of Parasitic and Medical Entomology, 32(01), 39-43.[龚正达, 文祥兵, & 李春富. (2025). 西藏自治区蚤目分类与区系研究 VI. 藏东南额蚤属一新种(蚤目: 细蚤科). 寄生虫与医学昆虫学报, 32(01), 39-43.]

[Frontopsylla (Frontopsylla) ochotona Gong, Wen & Li, 2025]

Frontopsylla (Frontopsylla) ochotona sp. nov. is closely related to Frontopsylla (Fr.) adixsterna Liu, Shao et Liu, 1976, but can be distinguished by the following characteristics: 1. In males, the immutable processes exhibit a wide, fingerlike shape with asymmetrical anterior and posterior edges at their ends. The posterior edge of st. VIII lacks a deep depression, and the distal arm of st. IX is split into two lobes. 2. In females, the posterior edge of the st. VII abdominal plate lacks a deep sinus, but the posterior end has a truncated or arc-shaped broad leaf. The posterior edge of t. VIII has a wide sinus, distinguishing it from F. adixsterna and other species in this genus. The type specimen was collected in Linzhi City, Xizang Autonomous Region of China, in November 2018, from an agricultural area at an altitude of approximately 3000 m. The host species include Ochotona sp., Niviventer confucianus, and Pitymys leucurus.

Traub R. A FOSSIL FLEA IN DOMINICAN AMBER: DESCRIPTION OF A NEW GENUS AND SPECIES (SIPHONAPTERA: RHOPALOPSYLLIDAE) WITH NOTES ON CONVERGENT EVOLUTION IN BIRD FLEAS AND THE HISTORICAL BIOGEOGRAPHY OF PERTINENT MAMMALS. (2025) Annals of Carnegie Museum, 90 (4), pp. 233 – 296

[*Pulicophoenix succinus* Traub, 2025, fossil]

[Rhopalopsyllidae, Rhopalopsyllinae]

A fossil flea in Dominican amber, *Pulicophoenix succinus*, new genus, new species (Siphonaptera: Rhopalopsyllidae, Rhopalopsyllinae) is described and figured. The fossil is 25–40 million years in age, with a putative date of lower Oligocene-upper Eocene, and exhibits some of the characteristic features seen in 24 genera or subgenera of bird fleas in five families. These diagnostic traits are discussed and illustrated for various examples of avian fleas, and it is concluded that *Pulicophoenix* was undoubtedly a bird flea and probably was a ‘perambulatory’ type that must actively seek out a host. Comparisons with mammalian-infesting fleas suggest that these specialized characters of bird fleas are somehow adaptive in nature and reflect the physiognomy and habits of the host. The family and subfamily levels in Siphonaptera evolved during the Cretaceous in some instances to the Miocene for others. Evolution has also proceeded slowly at the generic level for many fleas, over a period of millions of years.

In the Mesozoic Era, Africa and South America did not share a siphonapteran fauna of pulicid or any other extant group of fleas. The modern African faunas of mammals and fleas have Eurasian roots, even though some of their components originated in Africa. The forebears of the pulicid and ctenophthalmine fleas of South America, and those of their rodent hosts, originated in Africa and are thought to have rafted to South America in the Eocene. The only other true fossil fleas that have been named and described are four species of *Paleopsylla* Wagner, 1903 (an extant genus) in Baltic amber, and three pulicids in Dominican amber. It is possible that *Pulicophoenix* is still alive today, since very little is known about bird fleas of South America and the Greater Antilles, and since many other insect fossils in Dominican amber represent extant genera.

[Editor's note: Robert Traub passed away in 1996.]

Taxonomy

Önder, Z., Arslanhan, B. A., & Cifci, S. (2025). Molecular Characterization and Phylogenetic Analysis of *Pulex irritans* (Siphonaptera: Pulicidae) Fleas Collected from Sheep in Sivas Province, Türkiye. *Small Ruminant Research*, 253, art. no. 107624.

Chesters D. Where are the biggest gaps in phylogenetic coverage of insect diversity? (2025) *Systematic Entomology*, 50 (1), pp. 221 – 236

Gaps in phylogenetic knowledge are unlikely to be filled in an optimal manner in the absence of a quantitative descriptive framework of phylogenetic coverage to date and a strategy for addressing the remainder (the Darwinian Shortfall). One strategy would be modelling phylogenetic progress on a framework of insect diversity, such as a taxonomic database. I herein sampled existing phylogenetic coverage by collating a machine readable tree from each of 1000 insect publications. Processing comprised primarily taxonomic harmonization, the standardization of terminal labels and pruning of uninformative terminal sets such as taxon duplicates. The phylogeny database contained 94,173 unique species IDs over 154,938 terminals in total, with a respective mean and median number of species per phylogeny of 155 and 44. Omics phylogenies contained the most species on average, though not the most novel species, and mitogenome phylogenies contributed the fewest novel species. Synthesis phylogenies were very few in number, but nonetheless predicted to contribute most to increasing

phylogenetic coverage of insect diversity. 6.2% of the 970,000 species of the Catalogue of Life were contained amongst the terminals of the database of phylogenies. Phylogenetic coverage of insect families was often disproportionate to species-richness; those most undersampled were beetles and included families Curculionidae, Staphylinidae, Cerambycidae, and Scarabaeidae, and those with disproportionately high phylogenetic coverage included families of the dragonflies, bees, butterflies and ants. The work herein provides a foundation for quantification of the Darwinian Shortfall, and for shifting to an objective strategy for completing the insect Tree of Life.

K E Y W O R D S database, Phyloinformatics, standardization, synthesis phylogenetics, tree of life

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Pereira A., Cruz A., Novo T., Maia C. *Ctenocephalides felis* (cat flea)(2025) *Trends in Parasitology*, 41 (3), pp. 249 – 250

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Hosts and Distribution

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The maned wolf (*Chrysocyon brachyurus*), a canid with a wide distribution in South America, faces severe anthropogenic pressures resulting from habitat loss and fragmentation. Increasing circulation through anthropized environments intensifies contact with domestic animals and their ectoparasites, such as fleas of the genus *Ctenocephalides*, to which this species appears to be more susceptible. Moreover, little is known about the interaction process between this flea species and wild canids. Hematophagous arthropods, in general, have developed multiple adaptive and evolutionary strategies to ensure feeding success. Among these strategies is the ability to modulate host hemostatic and immunological mechanisms, including vasoconstriction, platelet aggregation, blood coagulation, and activation of the complement system, through biomolecules present in the saliva and/or midgut. In this context, the present study aimed to investigate and compare the interactions of salivary gland extracts (SGE) and intestinal extracts (IE) of *Ctenocephalides felis felis* on blood coagulation and the classical and alternative complement pathways of the maned wolf (*C. brachyurus*), dog (*Canis familiaris*), and cat (*Felis catus*). SGE and IE were obtained from the dissection of *C. felis felis* fleas and subsequently incubated with host serum or plasma, followed by analysis using immunoenzymatic assays (ELISA). The results demonstrated that SGE exhibited anticoagulant activity, prolonging clotting time by 53% in dogs, 35.5% in maned wolves, and 37% in cats, whereas IE showed no significant anticoagulant activity. In contrast, IE demonstrated the ability to inhibit the classical complement pathway, whereas SGE showed no detectable activity. Inhibition reached $63.7 \pm 5.8\%$ in dogs, $30.3 \pm 12.1\%$ in maned wolves, and $20.7 \pm 1.5\%$ in cats. None of the evaluated samples interfered with the alternative complement pathway. Statistical analyses revealed no significant differences among hosts regarding the anticoagulant and anti-complement activities of the tested extracts ($p > 0.05$). These findings contribute to a better understanding of immuno-ecological interactions, filling gaps in parasite–host dynamics and providing valuable insights to support management and conservation strategies for the maned wolf.

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highest abundance observed in *S. cuniculi* collected from cats, emphasizing the need for further investigation into its potential implications as vectors. Our results also demonstrate that the microbiota composition of fleas is largely influenced by the host they parasitize. The study of microbiota allowed for the ecological separation of flea species, with individuals from these five species clustering distinctly each other.

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